

INT.. BUCKINGHAM PALACE - PRIVATE BATHROOM - DAY (OCTOBER 26, 1965)

An ornate bathroom with marble fixtures and gilded mirrors. Crystal sconces cast warm light over royal appointments that have witnessed centuries of history.

The Beatles - JOHN LENNON (25), PAUL MCCARTNEY (23), GEORGE HARRISON (22), and RINGO STARR (25) - huddle nervously in their formal attire.

John checks the door, then produces a joint from his jacket pocket with casual irreverence.

JOHN

Right then. Last chance to calm the nerves before we meet Her Majesty.

PAUL

(weary but complicit)
I still think this is mad, John.
We're in the Queen's bloody loo!

JOHN

(lighting the joint)
We are where we are, lads. Best be relaxed. We're about to get medals.

George silently observes the ornate surroundings with detached amusement.

RINGO

(genuinely pleased, grinning)
My mum's going to be over the moon about all this.

We stay on the ornate mirror as they huddle beneath it – four working-class faces reflected in royal gold.

No one looks at the door.

Paul reluctantly accepts the joint when it's passed to him, his diplomatic nature warring with his anxiety.

PAUL

(taking a nervous drag)

This is exactly the sort of thing
that'll end up in the papers.
"Beatles Caught Smoking Cannabis in
Royal Bathroom." The headlines
write themselves.

JOHN

Good. Let them print it. Maybe
they'll finally understand we're
not their trained little monkeys.

PAUL

We just need to get through this
ceremony without incident. Smile,
say thank you, don't mention the
war... religion... Anything
controversial—

JOHN

(with a working-class
skepticism)

Or the fact that these are the same
medals they give to the boys who go
off and do the... actual work for
the Crown?

A moment of silence. George finally speaks, his voice quiet
and philosophical.

GEORGE

It's all just theatre, though,
really. All of it. Look at the
ceiling tiles. It's theatre.

John stubs out the joint and checks his reflection in the
ornate mirror.

JOHN

Right then. Do I look sufficiently
grateful to the Crown?

They straighten their attire, each processing the moment
according to their nature. John opens the door with casual
defiance.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Come on then, lads. Let's go meet
the establishment.

They file out, leaving behind the faint scent of cannabis and the echoes of their boyish laughter.

INT.. BUCKINGHAM PALACE - INVESTITURE ROOM - DAY (OCTOBER 26, 1965)

A room of silent, crushing history. Gold. Crystal. Dead monarchs watch from the walls.

QUEEN ELIZABETH II (39) stands on the dais, a portrait of practiced duty.

At a respectful distance, PRINCE PHILIP (44) watches – hands clasped behind his back, posture ramrod straight. Beside him, his uncle, LORD MOUNTBATTEN (65), surveys the room with the cool, analytical gaze of a career strategist.

THE BEATLES – JOHN, PAUL, GEORGE, and RINGO – wait their turn. They look impossibly young in their dark suits, shifting their weight, a nervous energy contained within the room's crushing formality.

Paul flashes a quick, charming smile when he catches the Queen's eye. Ringo looks genuinely thrilled to be there. George seems to be studying the architecture with philosophical detachment.

John, however, has a subtle, almost imperceptible smirk playing on his lips. A glint of the bathroom's rebellious humor remains in his eyes.

Philip's gaze locks onto him. His expression, already stern, tightens.

PRINCE PHILIP
(a low murmur to Mountbatten)
There's a carelessness about that one.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN
(without taking his eyes off them)
They call it authenticity, Philip.
It's the source of their influence.

Philip's jaw works silently in place of a reply. His hand moves to his naval service ribbons – an unconscious gesture,

touching the medals he perceives John to have mocked.

One by one they accept: Paul's diplomatic bow, George's quiet nod, Ringo's wide grin.

John steps forward, nods casually, eyes darting around the room.

To anyone else, it's nothing. To Philip, it's a fraction too casual – a sign of contempt. He looks away, his disapproval hardening into something colder.

We stay with Philip as John accepts the medal.

We don't see what John thinks of it – only what Philip decides it means.

INT.. BUCKINGHAM PALACE - CORRIDOR - LATER

The ceremony is over. An EQUERRY in formal attire approaches Philip and Mountbatten as they exit the Investiture Room.

EQUERRY

Your Royal Highness. Your car is waiting at the private west exit. The...

(apologetically clearing his throat)

musical group will be escorted to the press pen in the Grand Entrance.

Mountbatten clocks the phrase "musical group" – just a flicker of amusement. Philip gives a curt, dismissive nod and turns, leading Mountbatten down a long, silent, portrait-lined corridor.

We stay with the portraits on the walls.

Generations of royal ancestors watch them pass.

None of them approve of this modern chaos.

INT.. ANOTHER CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS

A different PALACE OFFICIAL leads THE BEATLES. The distant,

muffled sound of a CROWD grows louder.

PAUL
(to John, whispering
nervously)
Just smile and wave, our kid. Don't
say anything clever.

JOHN
(winks)
When have I ever done that?

They are led through a final set of doors and—

EXT.. BUCKINGHAM PALACE - GRAND ENTRANCE - DAY

—into a blinding wall of camera flash and shouted questions.
A chaotic scrum of REPORTERS pushes forward. The Beatles are
momentarily stunned before their public personas take over.

REPORTERS
(talking over each other)
Paul! Over here — What did she say?
— How does it feel? — Will you tour
again? — Ringo! — Smile!

PAUL
(charming, diplomatic)
We're just very honored..

RINGO
(grinning)
Me mum's going to frame it!

Laughter. Flash bulbs. A REPORTER shouts something to John —
we see his mouth moving, but we don't hear the question over
the chaos. John leans toward a microphone and says
something, grinning. Some reporters laugh. Others scribble
furiously.

We don't hear what John actually says.

We only see Paul's smile tighten slightly — he caught it,
whatever it was. The chaos continues.

INT.. PRINCE PHILIP'S PRIVATE STUDY - EVENING

A sanctuary of tradition. Deep shadows and perfect order. Leather-bound books line the walls. Polished silver frames reflect soft lamplight.

Philip, in an immaculate dark suit, pours a whiskey. The only sound is the clink of the decanter against crystal glass. He switches on a modest black-and-white television. The screen flickers to life. A BBC NEWSCASTER recaps the day.

BBC NEWSCASTER (V.O.)
...the highlight of today's
investiture was undoubtedly the
presentation of Members of the
Order of the British Empire to the
four members of The Beatles...

On screen: grainy footage of the press scrum we just witnessed. Philip sips his whiskey, watching with mild interest.

BBC NEWSCASTER (V.O.) (CONT'D)
However, an off-hand remark by Mr.
John Lennon has raised some
eyebrows.

We see John lean into the microphone. Now we hear him:

JOHN (ON TV)
I thought you had to drive tanks
and win wars and kill people to get
these things.

CLOSE ON PHILIP:

He freezes, whiskey glass halfway to his lips. The public mask of stoicism cracks and splinters, revealing a look of pure, unadulterated fury.

For a long moment, utter silence. Then he sets the glass down with a sharp, deliberate CLICK that echoes in the stillness.

PRINCE PHILIP
(to the screen, quietly)
You're not mocking the medal, boy.
You're mocking duty. Sacrifice.
Order.

(pacing, voice hardening)
Everything that built this
nation... while you learned guitar
chords in your...

(scowling with disgust)
...Liverpool basement.

His hand again moves to his naval service ribbons as he
picks up the telephone and dials with precise, military
movements.

PRINCE PHILIP (INTO PHONE)
Dickie.

(a pause, listening)
...mhm

(nodding slowly)
I'm in the study, let's talk.

He hangs up carefully, staring at the television, where
John's frozen image smirks at him with an air of cultural
superiority.

We stay with the television a moment longer.

John's face flickers, degrades, stabilizes – an insult
converted into an official-looking fact.

INT.. BRIAN EPSTEIN'S TOWNHOUSE - NIGHT (NOVEMBER 1965)

The height of mid-sixties sophistication. A pristine
townhouse filled with clinking champagne glasses, low
laughter, and the glow of recent triumph.

BRIAN EPSTEIN, 31, immaculate and radiant with pride, stands
at the center of the room as THE BEATLES enter together.

BRIAN
Y'alright, lads? To the boys.
Members of the Order of the British
Empire. I knew you could do it. I
always knew. To The Beatles!

He raises his glass.

ALL
To The Beatles!

They drink. The mood is electric, loose, familial.

RINGO holds his MBE medal up to the light, grinning like a schoolboy.

RINGO
My mum's going to frame this. Right
next to the good plates.

Laughter. PAUL is already half a step ahead, energized by the moment.

PAUL
This is brilliant, Eppy, truly. But
things like this - they don't just
last unless we keep them moving.
I've got a melody - could be the
next single. We need to book studio
time.

JOHN rolls his eyes, amused but alert.

JOHN
(teasing)
Always on the next single, he is.

He looks at Paul with a mixture of affection and exasperation.

JOHN (CONT'D)
We just got medals from the Queen,
and you're on about another silly
love song.

PAUL grins, unfazed.

PAUL
Someone once said, "The Beatles
were anti-materialistic." That's a
myth. John and I literally used to
sit down and say, "Now, let's write
a swimming pool."

John laughs – but the laugh fades as he stares into his glass, swirling the champagne.

JOHN

A swimming pool's one thing. But we can do more. The sounds, the words... they can actually say something. Millions of people are really listening to us - looking to us for inspiration.

BRIAN senses the shift, moves to smooth it over.

BRIAN

(gently)

Enjoy the moment, boys. This is a triumph. For all of us.

GEORGE, quiet on the edge of the sofa, watches John and Paul. He takes a measured sip of his drink.

GEORGE

It's all just part of the big machine though, isn't it? Doesn't matter what you feed into it. Same sausages come out the other end. Feels like something's missing.

The room stills for a beat.

Paul looks slightly stung. John smirks – familiar territory. Brian looks pained.

PAUL

Go on then, George. It's not like that.

BRIAN

Let's not turn tonight into a think-piece, eh? You've earned the right to just be happy for five minutes.

RINGO jumps in, cheerful, disarming.

RINGO

Hey, we're all in it. The four of us. Always has been. Best seat in the house, I've got.

The tension dissolves. George shrugs, half-conceding,

finishes his drink and pours another. John swirls his drink and watches the liquid move for a beat.

JOHN
(smiling, but distant)
Feels like the beginning of
something.. bigger..

John looks up. His smile grows wider as he raises his glass again.

JOHN
To Ringo. The only sane one among
us. And to the toppermost of the
poppermost!

They lift their glasses.

ALL
To the toppermost!

They drink, laughing again – the cracks papered over by history, affection, and shared momentum.

The camera holds on the four of them: united, victorious, and utterly unaware of the massive, brewing firestorm to come.

We stay with their glasses as they toast.

We don't see the future headlines being written.

Only celebration that will become evidence against them.

INT.. BUCKINGHAM PALACE - PRIVATE STUDY - NIGHT

Two days later. A decanter of whiskey sits on a silver tray. The air is thick with unspoken tension.

PRINCE PHILIP stands, facing the fireplace, rigid with controlled fury. LORD MOUNTBATTEN sits in a wingback chair, observing. A man who has mastered the control of his emotion.

QUEEN ELIZABETH II sits opposite him, hands folded in her lap. A corgi sleeps at her feet. She is a small island of calm in her husband's tempest.

PRINCE PHILIP

It's a complete mockery. Not just of the honour, but of the entire system. Of all of us.

He turns from the fire.

PRINCE PHILIP (CONT'D)

(low and intense)

I wore that uniform. I served on those ships. I knew men who received these medals – many posthumously – for doing their duty without question or comment. And we give the same honour to a... a popinjay who jokes about "killing people" for it.

(gesturing dismissively)

And, of course, the press lap it up. They treat him like a philosopher king. This is how it starts. The slow, steady erosion of respect. A complete failure to understand the proper order of things.

The Queen rises calmly and moves to a side table, adjusting a silver-framed photograph by a fraction of an inch. A small act of order in the face of chaos.

QUEEN ELIZABETH II

(quietly, her back to them)

The Crown has weathered unruly poets, pamphleteers, and public figures of every stripe. They are dramatic, their time passes, and the institution endures. One imagines the best course of action is simply to ignore it. It will be forgotten in a week.

PRINCE PHILIP

Will it? Or will it be seen as yet another sign that we have no authority? That we are irrelevant? This is not just a family, it's a

firm. And we must protect our
interests.

He looks to his uncle for support. Mountbatten takes a slow,
deliberate sip of his whiskey, allowing the silence to hang.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN
(thoughtfully)
Her Majesty's caution is, as
always, wise. A direct response
would be disastrous. It would make
them martyrs.

He turns to Philip, studying him with a mixture of concern
and mild amusement.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN (CONT'D)
You know, Philip, in my day we
fought actual revolutionaries.
Communists. Anarchists. People with
guns and manifestos. Not...
whatever these rascallions are up
to.

Philip glares.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN (CONT'D)
(leaning forward)
But you're right. Cultural power is
still power. And they're wielding
it, whether they know it or not. So
yes, we'll handle it. Quietly.
Strategically.

(smiling faintly)
Consider it a training exercise. If
we can't outmanoeuvre four
musicians from Liverpool, we've no
business running an intelligence
service.

The Queen turns, intrigued by the re-framing.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN (CONT'D)
(back to his stern, commanding
presence)
They are creating a new form of
nationalism. Not loyalty to a

country, but to a culture. To a tribe. It has its own anthems, its own leaders, its own symbols. It operates entirely outside our control. We can't command it, so we must persuade it. Or, failing that, dismantle it.

PRINCE PHILIP

Dismantle it? We can't have them arrested for irritating us anymore, Dickie.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN

Of course not. One doesn't use a battleship to sink a canoe. This requires a more... subtle approach. It's psychological. Think of them not as a monolith, but as a structure with existing fissures. We apply quiet, steady pressure to the weakest points, and they fracture from within.

He lets the idea hang in the air, his tone both charming and chilling.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN (CONT'D)

We amplify their natural tensions. We encourage their worst impulses. Lennon's paranoia. McCartney's ambition. Harrison's... spiritual wanderings. One doesn't send a gunboat. One simply ensures the right book on Eastern mysticism finds its way into the right hands at the right time.

(a faint, self-satisfied smile)

My great gift, as you know, is to accelerate the inevitable.

He lets the words hang in the air for a beat before delivering the name with the finality of a war command.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN (CONT'D)

We shall call it Operation Minuet.
A delicate dance, performed in the
shadows.

Philip's anger begins to cool, replaced by the focused
intensity of a commander. He likes this. It's a plan.

PRINCE PHILIP
Operation Minuet. And who executes
this dance?

LORD MOUNTBATTEN
I have men at the firm. Not my
finest, I'll admit, but suitable
for this kind of work. They
understand the art of the nudge.

Philip nods, satisfied. He finally sits down, the immediate
crisis replaced with a long-term strategy. He looks to his
wife. There is an urgency in his eyes – a plea for her to
see the necessity.

The Queen is silent for a long moment, stroking her sleeping
dog. She meets her husband's gaze, her own unreadable,
before looking away toward the dark window.

QUEEN ELIZABETH II
And one presumes this Operation
Minuet has a budget?

We don't get a clear "yes."

We only get the photograph – nudged into perfect alignment.

Order restored. Permission granted in the language she
trusts.

Mountbatten and Philip exchange a look. Her question, so
mundane and practical, is her reluctant, weary consent.

INT.. MI5 BRIEFING ROOM - DAY

The room is an exercise in government-mandated misery.
Fluorescent lights hum over a scarred wooden table.

SIR DEREK FINCHLEY (54), impeccably dressed, sits at the
head of the table, a picture of calm authority. Beside him,

LORD MOUNTBATTEN's (65) presence lends the drab room an unearned gravity.

Across from them sit NIGEL FINCH (48) and CLIVE BARROW (41). Nigel is perfectly still, his hands clasped around a pen, his expression neutral. Clive fidgets, buzzing with an energy the room cannot contain, his eyes darting between the two powerful men.

SIR DEREK

Gentlemen. Thank you for coming. We have a matter of some national sensitivity. A delicate but vital undertaking that requires the utmost discretion.

He pulls a thin folder from his very fancy, oversized briefcase and slides it across the table. It is labeled "OPERATION MINUET".

SIR DEREK (CONT'D)

This initiative concerns a unique cultural asset. One that has... begun to operate outside of its preferred parameters.

Mountbatten cuts in, his voice like iron.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN

To be precise, it's become a cultural threat. Their influence is organic and it's spreading... It's infectious - cancerous. It can't be commanded, and must be managed with nuance.

Clive leans forward, his eyes wide with excitement. He opens the folder and his face lights up.

CLIVE

The Beatles. Of course. A classic case of aesthetic subversion! Their semiotic framework is... it's pure psychological warfare wrapped in a three-minute pop song! We must eradicate this disease!

Nigel slowly closes his eyes for a single, weary beat. Two

fingers land on each temple as he opens his eyes and looks at Sir Derek.

NIGEL

And the objective, sir? What, precisely, are we to... achieve?

SIR DEREK

An excellent question, Nigel. The objective is not elimination, but realignment. We encourage the existing entropic forces within the group dynamic. We help them fall apart. Lord Mountbatten has devised a multi-pronged approach.

Mountbatten points a finger at Clive.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN

Barrow. You'll take the primary asset. Lennon. The file suggests he is prone to paranoia, intellectual vanity, and grandiosity. Your job is to amplify those traits. Feed his ego. Make him believe he is a revolutionary, not a pop star. He must become the public threat we already perceive him to be.

CLIVE

(breathless)

A... cognitive infiltration. Sir, I've spent significant time developing a methodology, perfect for this. I call it 'The Klaus Technique'. I pose as a German art critic... discuss the Situationists... Guy Debroad, perhaps. I gain his trust through aesthetic symbiosis... It's truly revolutionary.

Nigel makes a small, almost inaudible sigh. Mountbatten ignores Clive's outburst and turns to Nigel.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN

Finch. You will take the other two.

McCartney and Harrison. McCartney
fancies himself a diplomat, a
traditionalist. We will flatter
that. Make him feel the
establishment values him more.
Create an ideological wedge. As for
Harrison... the file is thin. He
seems interested in... sitars.

NIGEL
... Sitar, sir?

LORD MOUNTBATTEN
Indeed. Some sort of guitar-harp
hybrid as I understand it. Nurture
that. A man focused on finding the
perfect drone is a man less focused
on the team. It's a simple pressure
point.

Nigel does his best to get something down in his notebook,
but after crossing out several misspellings of sitar, just
ends up with: "SITAR?"

He taps his pen against the notebook a few times.

He writes: "ENCOURAGE SITAR STUDIES"

NIGEL
And the drummer, sir? Starr?

Mountbatten waves a dismissive hand.

LORD MOUNTBATTEN
The drummer is psychologically
inert. A control group. Ignore him.

Sir Derek closes his own (entirely empty now) portfolio with
a soft click.

SIR DEREK
Excellent. I'm confident your
considerable expertise will guide
you toward the most... appropriate
resolutions. Keep me apprised of
your progress. Through the
appropriate channels, of course.
Gentlemen.

He and Mountbatten stand and leave. They don't look back.

Nigel and Clive are left alone in the humming silence of the room. Clive is practically vibrating with joy, already lost in his delusions of grandeur.

Nigel stares down at the words he's just written, tapping his pen against his shoulder with a look of utter confusion on his face: "encourage sitar studies?"

He slowly, precisely, underlines the phrase twice.

INT.. ABBEY ROAD STUDIOS - NIGHT (NOVEMBER 1965)

The legendary Studio Two is alive with late-night creativity. Instruments scattered everywhere, ashtrays overflowing, empty tea cups forming rings on every surface. The Beatles are deep in the zone, working on what will become their most introspective album.

GEORGE sits cross-legged on the floor, a SITAR balanced across his lap. He plucks tentatively at the strings, creating haunting, unfamiliar sounds that seem to float through the studio like incense.

JOHN hunches over his acoustic guitar, scribbling lyrics on the back of an envelope. His hair is getting longer, his clothes more casual. There's an intensity to his concentration felt by all in the room.

PAUL paces behind the piano, humming a melody, occasionally stopping to play a few bars. His energy is focused but restless.

RINGO sits behind his kit, not playing, just listening with the patience of someone who's learned when to wait.

GEORGE
(to the sitar, frustrated)
Go on then... Norwegian wood...
what are you trying to tell me?

He adjusts his fingers, tries again. The sound is closer to what he wants - mysterious, Eastern, unlike anything The Beatles have done before.

JOHN

(looking up from his lyrics)
Y'allright, our kid? It's not the
wood talking. It's you.

PAUL
(stopping his pacing)
Right, but will Radio Caroline play
it? Will the kids understand it?

JOHN
(with edge)
Maybe it's time they learned
something new, eh? Can't keep
singing about holding hands
forever, can we?

PAUL
I'm not saying we should. I'm just
saying we need to bring them with
us, not leave them behind.

In the control room, visible through the glass, two figures
in white coats move about with tea trolleys. NIGEL FINCH,
45, carries himself with the resigned dignity of a man
serving Earl Grey when he'd rather be analyzing Soviet
missile trajectories. CLIVE BARROW, 38, vibrates with barely
contained excitement, treating this assignment like the
artistic infiltration of the century.

NIGEL
(to Clive, under his breath)
Remember, we're invisible. Tea
service staff are background noise.

CLIVE
(whispering intensely)
Do you realize what we're
witnessing? The birth of a new
aesthetic paradigm! This is... this
is revolutionary consciousness
emerging through sonic
experimentation!

NIGEL
It's a guitar with extra strings,
Clive.

Clive pulls out a small notebook and begins scribbling

frantically.

CLIVE

(writing)

"Subject Harrison exploring Eastern
mysticisms... possible Communist
influences... through Indian
classical music..."

Nigel looks over at Clive's notebook, sighs, and shakes his head with frustration before collecting himself.

NIGEL

Clive, the sitar is not a Communist plot.

CLIVE

(frustration bubbling in his eyes)

What? How can you be certain?

(a look of wonder enters his eyes)

What if the strings are tuned to...
to Marxist frequencies? Or worse?

Nigel stares at him for a long moment, then picks up the tea tray.

NIGEL

I'm going to serve tea.

He enters the studio proper, moving with professional invisibility.

NIGEL

(politely)

Tea, gentlemen?

The Beatles barely acknowledge him - they're too deep in their creative process. George continues working with the sitar, now finding a haunting melody that weaves through "Norwegian Wood."

JOHN

(to George, excited)

That's it! That's the sound I was
hearing in my head. Like... like

memories of a place you've never
been.

GEORGE

(pleased but philosophical)
That's the thing though, isn't it?
The music.. It takes you to the
places that don't yet exist.

Paul sits at the piano, begins playing the opening chords of
what will become "In My Life." The melody is wistful,
mature, a step up from their earlier work.

PAUL

(singing softly)
"There are places I remember... all
my life though some have
changed..."

JOHN

(joining in, harmonizing)
"Some forever, not for better...
some have gone and some remain..."

Nigel sets down tea cups, his movements precise and
unobtrusive. But his eyes are alert, taking in everything.
Like Clive, he recognizes something significant is happening
- he's just self-aware enough to know that he'll never
understand what.

RINGO

(to no one in particular)
Funny how growing up makes you look
backwards, isn't it?

JOHN

(looking up from his lyrics)
That's exactly what this is about,
our kid. All these places and
people that shaped us... but now
we're free to explore... to become
something different, aren't we?.

He holds up the envelope with his lyrics.

JOHN (CONT'D)

"Though I know I'll never lose
affection for people and things

that went before..."

PAUL

(nodding)

"I know I'll often stop and think about them..."

GEORGE

(still playing the sitar)

It's like... maya. The illusion of permanence. Everything changes, but the love remains.

PAUL

(slightly confused)

Maya?

GEORGE

Hindu concept. The world as we see it is just... surface. Underneath, everything's connected.

In the control room, Clive is practically hyperventilating.

CLIVE

(scribbling furiously)

"Hindu concepts... Eastern philosophy... Subject Harrison is likely under foreign influence"

Through the glass, he watches George demonstrate a basic sitar technique to John, who tries to replicate it on his guitar.

CLIVE (CONT'D)

(to himself)

This is it. This is how they mean to corrupt the youth. Through... through transcendental guitar technique... What else could all those extra strings be for?

Nigel returns to the control room, sets down the empty tea tray.

NIGEL

Any earth-shattering discoveries while I was gone?

CLIVE
(breathless)
Nigel, they're discussing Hindu philosophy! And look at Lennon's lyrics - "places I remember, not for better".... "lost affection for the people and things that went before" - clearly a rejection of British traditions!

A small beep. Nigel touches a button on his earpiece.

NIGEL
(after a pause)
No sign of Mr. Epstein, sir. Assume he remains focused on the Mayfair aesthetic matrix.

Nigel takes a deep breath and directs his attention back to Clive.

NIGEL
Or... And he me out...

(looking through the glass)
They're writing songs about growing up.

On the studio floor, the four Beatles are now gathered around George's sitar. There's something almost ritualistic about the moment - four young men from Liverpool discovering sounds that will change popular music forever.

JOHN
(thoughtful)
You know what's mad? Six months ago we were singing "Help!" and now...

He gestures at the sitar, at Paul's introspective piano melody, at the notebooks full of philosophical lyrics.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Now we're trying to figure out what it all means.

PAUL
Maybe that's what happens when you stop running long enough to think.

GEORGE
(smiling)
Maybe the music's just catching up
with who we really are.

RINGO
(with his characteristic
wisdom)
Either way, it's going to confuse
the shite out of people.

They all laugh - a moment of genuine camaraderie before the
storm that's coming.

In the control room, Clive closes his notebook with
satisfaction.

CLIVE
(to Nigel)
Mark my words - this "Rubber Soul"
album will be the beginning of
their downfall. All this
introspection and Eastern
influence... it's exactly the kind
of intellectual pretension that
alienates the common man.

NIGEL
(dryly)
Yes, Clive. I'm sure the British
public will be horrified by
thoughtful lyrics.

CLIVE
You'll see. This is where Operation
Minuet begins to bear fruit.
They're destroying themselves...
with artistic ambition!

Through the glass, The Beatles continue working, unaware
they're being watched, unaware that their natural evolution
as artists is being interpreted as subversion.

We stay behind the glass with Nigel and Clive.

We can see the band, but we can't quite hear the nuance –
just enough to misunderstand it.

MONTAGE - RUBBER SOUL HITS #1 - DAY (DECEMBER 1965)

A rapid-fire sequence showing the album's unprecedented success:

— EXT. RECORD STORE - OHIO - DAY:

A massive crowd surrounds a small record shop. A TEENAGE GIRL, 16, clutches a copy of "Rubber Soul" to her chest, tears streaming down her face.

TEENAGE GIRL
(screaming to her friend)
They're getting even better! This
isn't just pop music anymore - this
is art!

She holds up the album cover, studying the distorted faces with reverence.

— INT. UNIVERSITY DORMITORY - LONDON - DAY:

A COLLEGE STUDENT, 20, plays "Norwegian Wood" on a small record player. His ROOMMATE listens intently, both smoking cigarettes and looking deeply contemplative.

COLLEGE STUDENT
(in awe)
This is the future of music, lad.
They've gone from "Love Me Do"
to... to this, innit?

ROOMMATE
That sound.. Never heard that sound
in a pop record before.

— INT. RADIO STATION - LONDON - DAY:

A RADIO DJ, 35, sits before his microphone, practically vibrating with excitement. Charts and sales figures are scattered across his desk.

RADIO DJ
(breathlessly, into
microphone)

Ladies and gentlemen, we have just received the latest sales figures for "Rubber Soul," and I can barely believe what I'm reading. Number one simultaneously in Britain AND America. The Beatles have done it again, but this time... this time it's different.

He holds up the album, studying the cover.

RADIO DJ (CONT'D)

This isn't the same band that sang "She Loves You." This is something deeper. This album is going to change everything.

INTERCUT — INT. BUCKINGHAM PALACE PRIVATE STUDY — DAY:

PRINCE PHILIP sits rigidly behind his desk, watching a small black-and-white television. The radio DJ's voice continues over the TV audio. Philip's jaw tightens with each word of praise.

On the TV screen: footage of screaming fans, record store crowds, newspaper headlines proclaiming "BEATLES EVOLVE" and "RUBBER SOUL: THE SOUND OF THE FUTURE."

Philip reaches for the remote and turns up the volume, his knuckles white.

RADIO DJ (V.O.)

(continuing from radio)

The sophistication of songs like "In My Life" and "Norwegian Wood"... it's as if The Beatles have graduated from entertainers to... to cultural philosophers.

Philip's face darkens. He stands abruptly, walks to the window overlooking the palace grounds.

PRINCE PHILIP

(scoffing coldly to himself)

Cultural philosophers.

He turns back to the television, where footage shows young

people gathered in record shops, discussing the album with the intensity usually reserved for political movements.

PRINCE PHILIP (CONT'D)
(under his breath)
Exactly what I was afraid of.

BACK TO MONTAGE:

— EXT. RECORD STORE - MANCHESTER - DAY:

Another crowd, this one more diverse - teenagers, college students, even some adults. Everyone clutching copies of "Rubber Soul." The energy is different from typical Beatlemania - more thoughtful, more intense.

A YOUNG WOMAN, 22, emerges from the store, carefully examining the album liner notes.

YOUNG WOMAN
(to her boyfriend)
"Though I know I'll never lose affection for people and things that went before." These aren't just lyrics, they're... they're Shelley. When did pop stars start writing like Shelley?

— INT. COFFEE SHOP - LIVERPOOL - DAY:

A group of TEENAGERS, 16-18, huddle around a table, the album spread between them like a sacred text. They're not screaming - they're analyzing.

TEENAGER #1
The sitar on "Norwegian Wood" - that's Indian classical music. They're bringing Eastern philosophy into Western pop.

TEENAGER #2
"In My Life" is just... pure. It's recollection, not just a love song. It's about being an adult and still remembering your street, your mates, isn't it? It gives all our

stories weight, it does.

BACK TO:

— INT. BUCKINGHAM PALACE PRIVATE STUDY - CONTINUOUS:

Philip watches this footage with growing alarm. The TV now shows a NEWS REPORTER standing outside Abbey Road Studios.

NEWS REPORTER (ON TV)
What we're witnessing isn't just
musical evolution - it's cultural
revolution. The Beatles have
transformed from teen idols into
something far more significant:
voices of a generation coming of
age.

Philip snaps off the television. The room falls into heavy silence.

He walks to his desk, picks up a framed photograph of himself in naval uniform, stares at it for a long moment.

PRINCE PHILIP
(quietly, to the photograph)
Twenty years of service. Twenty
years of duty. And here we are, up
against four deadbeats from
Liverpool who dare reshape British
culture.

He sets down the photograph with deliberate control.

PRINCE PHILIP (CONT'D)
(with growing intensity)
This is the front line. This
cultural rot. We're not fighting
the Russians anymore. We're
fighting anarchists with guitars
who think a song about a carpet is
poetry...

He takes a deep, calculated sip of whiskey. His gaze points to nothing in particular.

PRINCE PHILIP (CONT'D)

(under his breath, coldly)
Not on my watch.

We don't see the celebrating crowds anymore.

We remain on Philip's hands as they tighten around his whiskey glass.

The glass does not break.

Neither will his resolve.

FINAL MONTAGE SHOT:

— EXT. RECORD STORE - LONDON - DAY:

The largest crowd yet - hundreds of people queued around the block. The energy is celebratory but also reverent, as if they're participating in something historically significant.

PUSH IN on the crowd to reveal, in the background, a familiar MI5 SURVEILLANCE VAN parked across the street.

— INT. MI5 SURVEILLANCE VAN - CONTINUOUS:

NIGEL FINCH sits behind the wheel, staring through the windshield at the massive crowd. His usual bureaucratic composure is cracking. He looks overwhelmed, almost defeated.

He picks up his radio, speaks into it with weary resignation.

NIGEL (INTO RADIO)
Control, this is Surveillance Unit
Seven. I'm looking at roughly...
three.. four hundred civilians
queued for Beatles merchandise.
Repeat: three to four hundred.

He pauses, watching as more people join the queue.

NIGEL (CONT'D)
(quietly, to himself, rubbing
his temples)
And they expect me to conduct a
covert operation against this?

He looks up helplessly at the crowd - young and old, working class and middle class, all united in their enthusiasm for an album that's clearly more than entertainment.

A YOUNG BOY, 12, walks past the van carrying his copy of RUBBER SOUL like a treasure. He's studying the liner notes - the track list, the credits - with the precise, total focus of a young officer studying a battle plan.

Nigel watches the boy disappear into the crowd, then looks down at his surveillance notes. Pages and pages of observations about four young men from Liverpool.

NIGEL
(into radio, with growing
doubt)
Control... I think we're going to
need a bigger bus.

The camera slowly pulls back from the van, showing it dwarfed by the massive crowd celebrating The Beatles' artistic evolution.

INT.. THE ASHER FAMILY HOME (WIMPOLE STREET) - ATTIC ROOM - DAY (JANUARY 1966)

A cramped but vibrant room under a slanted ceiling. This is Paul's creative cocoon. It's dominated by a small upright piano, littered with handwritten lead sheets. Guitars stand in the corner. Stacks of vinyl--Motown, Luciano Berio, American blues--sit next to a copy of a Harold Pinter play.

A framed photo of a smiling JANE ASHER sits on the piano.

PAUL MCCARTNEY (23), dressed in a sharp knit sweater, sits at the piano, pencil tucked behind his ear. He's deep in thought, playing a simple, melancholic melody--the theme for "The Family Way."

He stops. His fingers idly drift into the iconic opening chords of "Yesterday," a moment of muscle memory. He catches himself, a small, private smile on his face -- that was then. He shakes his head slightly, getting back to the task at hand. He picks up the pencil and makes a crisp notation on the score. He's a craftsman at work.

DISSOLVE TO:

INT.. EMI STUDIOS, STUDIO ONE - DAY:

The vast, hallowed space, normally home to rock and roll, is now filled with a 30-PIECE ORCHESTRA. String, woodwind, and brass sections, all in formal attire. The air is one of hushed, professional reverence.

Paul stands beside the CONDUCTOR (60s, distinguished, a George Martin type), looking slightly out of his element but exuding a quiet confidence. He's listening intently, the professional.

PAUL

(quietly, to the Conductor)

It needs to feel hopeful, but with
a bit of a northern sadness to it.
You know? Like a Sunday afternoon
when the rain's just stopped.

The Conductor nods, understanding completely. He raises his baton.

CONDUCTOR

From the top, gentlemen. "Love in
the Open Air."

The baton falls. The orchestra begins to play Paul's theme. It's lush, romantic, and sophisticated. It sounds like a 'proper' piece of film music. Paul closes his eyes, listening, a small smile playing on his lips. This is different. This is legitimacy.

INTERCUT - INT. EMI STUDIOS - CONTROL ROOM - CONTINUOUS:

Behind the thick glass, NIGEL FINCH (48) and CLIVE BARROW (41) watch the scene unfold. They are dressed in drab suits, posing as "acoustic consultants" from the BBC.

Clive leans forward, scribbling furiously in his notebook, his eyes alight with delusional insight.

CLIVE

Observe, Nigel. The subject is
pivoting. This isn't rebellion;
it's infiltration. A strategic move
to co-opt the cultural
establishment from within.

Nigel sighs, a sound of pure, existential weariness. He adjusts his wire-rimmed spectacles.

NIGEL
He's writing a film score, Clive.

CLIVE
(ignoring him)
Precisely! It's a calculated play for legitimacy. He's courting the very power structure Lennon affects to despise. A classic pincer movement against the band's own internal contradictions. This is... aesthetic co-option.

Nigel makes a single, precise note in his own logbook:
"Subject P. McCartney composing instrumental music for a film score."

We stay with Nigel's pen as it writes.

We don't hear the orchestra anymore.

Only the scratch of ink on paper turning art into evidence.

BACK IN THE STUDIO:

The orchestra finishes the piece with a final, beautiful chord that hangs in the air. There is a moment of silence, then the musicians lightly tap their bows on their music stands in a sign of professional respect.

Paul beams. It's not the screaming of fans; it's the quiet approval of his peers. He gives the orchestra a small, appreciative "thumbs-up."

PAUL
(to the Conductor)
That's the one. Boss.

INT.. EMI STUDIOS - CONTROL ROOM - CONTINUOUS:

Clive watches Paul's thumbs-up, interpreting it with manic intensity.

CLIVE

(a hushed, triumphant whisper)
Did you see that? A clear signal.
He's secured the asset. The entire
orchestral establishment. He's
building his own cultural army.

He underlines a sentence in his notebook twice: "SUBJECT A:
MCCARTNEY - IDEOLOGICAL PIVOT COMPLETE."

Nigel slowly closes his logbook. He stares through the glass
at Paul, who is now cheerfully chatting with the first
violinist. He sees a talented, ambitious young man being
influenced by his surroundings. Nothing more, nothing less.

NIGEL
(to himself, quietly)
And we're the ones meant to be
protecting the nation. God help us
all.

The camera pushes in on Paul, who laughs at something the
violinist says. He looks happy and confident. He's
completely unaware of the absurd take-aways an ambitious
agent is making in the next room.

INT.. JOHN'S WEYBRIDGE HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY (JANUARY
1966)

A Tudor-style mansion that screams expensive success but
whispers spiritual emptiness. The living room is dominated
not by luxury furniture, but by books. Stacks and stacks of
them—philosophy, religion, Eastern mysticism, poetry—cover
every surface like intellectual debris.

a-JOHN LENNON (25) sits cross-legged on the Persian carpet,
surrounded by open books. His hair is getting longer, his
clothes more casual. He's deeply absorbed in reading *The
Passover Plot* by Hugh J. Schonfield, making notes in the
margins with intense concentration.

a-Scattered around him: *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*, works
by Aldous Huxley, books on Hinduism and Buddhism, volumes of
poetry. This isn't casual reading—this is a man desperately
searching for something.

JOHN
(reading aloud, to himself)

"The historical Jesus was a man,
not a god... the Christ of faith is
a creation of the early church..."

He looks up from the book, staring out the large window at
the manicured suburban landscape. His expression is
troubled, questioning.

JOHN (CONT'D)
(quietly)
If that's true... then what exactly
have we all been believing?

CYNTHIA LENNON (26) enters carrying a tea tray. She's
blonde, pretty, but there's worry in her eyes as she surveys
the chaos of books and her increasingly distant husband.

CYNTHIA
John? I've brought you some tea.

John doesn't look up, already reaching for another book—this
one on Eastern philosophy.

JOHN
(distracted)
Mmm. Thanks, love.

a-Cynthia sets the tray down carefully, moving books to make
space. She picks up *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*, examining
it with concern.

CYNTHIA
John... you've been reading for
hours. Julian's been asking for his
daddy.

JOHN
(still reading)
In a minute, Cyn. This is... this
is important.

He holds up a passage from the philosophy book.

JOHN (CONT'D)
(excited, finally looking at
her)
Listen to this—"All conditioned
things are impermanent. Work out

your salvation with diligence."
Buddha's last words. Doesn't that
just... doesn't that change
everything?

CYNTHIA
(gently)
I don't know, love. Does it?

JOHN
(growing animated)
Don't you see? We've been living
this... this illusion. Fame, money,
screaming fans—it's all maya. Hindu
concept. It means illusion, the
veil that covers reality.

Cynthia sits on the edge of the sofa, watching her husband
with growing concern.

CYNTHIA
You sound like George with all his
Indian music talk.

JOHN
(defensive)
Maybe George is onto something.
Maybe we all are. Maybe that's why
the music's changing, why we can't
just sing "Love Me Do" anymore.

He gestures at the books around him.

JOHN (CONT'D)
There's got to be more than this,
Cyn. More than just... being
famous.

CYNTHIA
(worried)
But John... you're scaring me a
bit. All this talk about illusions
and... and questioning everything.
What about us? What about Julian?
Are we illusions too?

John looks at her. His intensity softens.

JOHN
(reaching for her hand)
No, love. You're real. Julian's
real. It's just... everything else.
The whole bloody circus.

He picks up a newspaper from the coffee table—headlines
about Beatles tours, fan hysteria, commercial success.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Look at this. "Beatles Conquer
America Again." "Rubber Soul Breaks
Records." It's like we're not even
people anymore. We're... products.

CYNTHIA
Maybe you need to get out more. See
people. Instead of just... reading
all the time.

JOHN
(with a bitter laugh)
See people? Cyn, I can't walk down
the street without being mobbed.
This house is the only place I can
think.

He stands, walks to the window, staring out at suburban
perfection.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Sometimes I feel like I'm
disappearing. Like John Lennon the
person is being eaten alive by John
Lennon the Beatle.

EXT.. JOHN'S WEYBRIDGE HOME - CONTINUOUS

Across the street, NIGEL FINCH sits in a nondescript sedan,
watching the house through binoculars. A notebook rests on
his lap.

NIGEL
(into small tape recorder)
Subject continues extensive reading
program. Observed titles include
works on Eastern religion,

alternative Christianity, and...

He adjusts the binoculars, squinting at book spines through the window.

NIGEL (CONT'D)

...what appears to be Buddhist philosophy. Recommend immediate investigation of local bookshops for purchase records.

Through the glass, John paces, gesticulating as he talks to Cynthia.

NIGEL (CONT'D)

(continuing)

Subject appears agitated. Possible radicalization in progress. Increased isolation may be accelerating ideological drift.

He lowers the binoculars, writes: "Day 47 – Intellectual subversion continues."

We remain on Nigel's notebook.

We don't see John's face anymore - only the words that will become his indictment.

INT.. JOHN'S WEYBRIDGE HOME - CONTINUOUS

John is back on the floor, reading from a book on comparative religion. Cynthia watches uneasily.

JOHN

(reading aloud)

"The kingdom of heaven is within you." That's what Jesus actually said. Not in some church. Not through some priest. Within you.

He looks up, eyes alight.

JOHN (CONT'D)

What if organized religion got it all wrong, Cyn? What if the real message got buried under centuries

of politics and power?

CYNTHIA

(quietly)

John... you're starting to sound like you think you know better than the Church of England.

JOHN

(with conviction)

Maybe I do. Maybe we all do, if we just think for ourselves.

a-He picks up *The Passover Plot*.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Schonfield traces how the Jesus story got changed. Mythologized. The real Jesus was probably just a teacher. Like Buddha. Like anyone who tries to wake people up.

Cynthia stands.

CYNTHIA

I think I'll go check on Julian.

JOHN

(oblivious)

You know what's mad? We probably reach more people with our music than Jesus ever did.

Cynthia pauses at the doorway.

CYNTHIA

(quietly)

Just be careful, John. Some thoughts are dangerous to think out loud.

She exits. John stares at the window.

JOHN

(to himself)

If Christianity is just another myth... then what else are we meant to believe without question?

EXT.. JOHN'S WEYBRIDGE HOME - CONTINUOUS

Nigel lowers his binoculars, satisfied.

NIGEL
(into recorder)
Subject questioning fundamental
religious beliefs. Recommend
escalation. Potential leverage
identified.

He starts the engine and drives off.

The camera holds on John through the window—brilliant,
restless, seeking truth—unaware his spiritual journey is
being logged as ammunition.

INT.. LONDON EVENING STANDARD OFFICE - DAY (FEBRUARY 1966)

The newsroom buzzes with Fleet Street energy. Typewriters
clack. Phones ring. Cigarette smoke hangs in the air.

MAUREEN CLEAVE, 32, sharp and professional, sits at her desk
reviewing notes.

She glances at a discarded fan magazine nearby. The cover
reads "PAUL'S FAVORITE FOODS." She rolls her eyes.

Her own desk is crowded with Beatles coverage. Reviews of
"Rubber Soul," concert reports, and thoughtful essays on
cultural impact and artistic evolution. She picks up a copy
of "Rubber Soul" and studies the cover.

MAUREEN
(to herself)
From "Love Me Do" to this in three
years...

She writes on her notepad: "Individual profiles. Who are
they becoming?"

DEREK TAYLOR, 35, the entertainment editor, approaches with
a cup of tea.

DEREK
Maureen, tell me you have something
for next week. The editor thinks

we're neglecting the cultural event
of the century.

MAUREEN

(looking up)

I've been thinking. Everyone covers
them as a group. The phenomenon.
The screaming. But not who they are
as individuals.

She gestures to the album.

MAUREEN (CONT'D)

This isn't the same band that
recorded "Please Please Me."
They're becoming artists. Thinkers.
John especially. He's reading more.
Questioning more.

DEREK

(skeptical)

They're pop stars. What am I
missing?

MAUREEN

(interrupting, passionate)

Are they? "In My Life." Indian
music. Studio experimentation.
These are cultural leaders, not
just entertainers.

She picks up a slim paperback from her desk. "Why I Am Not a
Christian — Bertrand Russell." Its pages are dog-eared,
underlined.

MAUREEN (CONT'D)

The youth are changing. Churches
are empty. Concert halls are full.
The Beatles are reflecting that
shift and driving it.

DEREK

(considering)

So what are you proposing?

MAUREEN

Individual profiles. In-depth
interviews. Ideas. Influences. Who

they're becoming.

She spreads out her notes.

MAUREEN (CONT'D)

Start with John. He's more candid than ever. The intellectual engine of the band. I want him at home, surrounded by his books.

DEREK

(warming)

"The Thinking Beatle"?

MAUREEN

Exactly. Who he is when he's not performing.

Across the newsroom, partially hidden behind a filing cabinet, CLIVE BARROW lurks in disguise as a maintenance worker, toolbox in hand.

He scribbles furiously in a notebook.

CLIVE

(whispering)

"Individual profiles"...

"intellectual leader"...

He writes: "PRESS MOBILIZING. COORDINATED ATTACK IMMINENT."

DEREK

And you think Lennon will agree?

MAUREEN

He wants it. He's frustrated with teen-mag questions. He wants to be taken seriously.

DEREK

All right. Set it up. Do it right.

MAUREEN

(confident)

I will. John Lennon has a lot to say about the state of the world.

Clive nearly drops his toolbox.

CLIVE
(urgent whisper)
"State of the world"... subversive
agenda confirmed!

He hurries off, scattering papers.

OFFICE WORKER
Oi! Watch it!

CLIVE
(panicked, fake accent)
Sorry, guv. Maintenance business.
Urgent maintenance.

He flees, leaving behind a screwdriver.

Maureen continues, unaware.

MAUREEN
I'll call Brian Epstein. Something
intimate. Weybridge. Somewhere John
feels comfortable.

DEREK
Just remember. He's still one of
the most famous people in the
world.

MAUREEN
(smiling)
That's what makes it interesting.

CUT TO:

EXT.. LONDON EVENING STANDARD BUILDING - DAY

Clive bursts outside and rushes to a payphone.

CLIVE
(into phone, breathless)
Nigel, it's worse than we thought.
The press is coordinating
psychological profiling.

INTERCUT WITH:

INT.. MI5 OFFICE - DAY

NIGEL FINCH sits at his desk, rubbing his temples.

NIGEL
(weary)
Clive, what exactly did you hear?

CLIVE
(over phone)
In-depth interviews. Individual
profiles. Lennon's ideas.
Influences.

NIGEL
(sighing)
Clive, that sounds like journalism.

CLIVE
(indignant)
This is how it starts!

NIGEL
Come back to the office. We need to
talk.

CLIVE
(over phone)
This interview will expose his true
agenda.

Nigel hangs up and stares at the phone.

NIGEL
(to himself)
Or it'll be a normal interview with
a pop star who reads books.

He taps his pen a few times with a furrowed brow.

He writes: "Evening Standard profile on LENNON. Monitor
closely."

We stay with the words as they dry on the page.

We begin to realize that this is how conspiracies begin: not
with plots, but with paperwork.

INT.. BRIAN EPSTEIN'S OFFICE - DAY (FEBRUARY 1966)

A tastefully modern office in central London. Sleek furniture, framed Beatles memorabilia on the walls. The large desk is a model of organized chaos: neat stacks of contracts, a brimming but orderly inbox tray, and a leather-bound calendar filled with appointments.

MAUREEN CLEAVE, 32, sits comfortably but alert across from BRIAN EPSTEIN, 31, who reviews a document with subtle intensity.

MAUREEN

I'm not interested in fluff, Brian.
This isn't for a teen mag. I want
real access. Thoughtful
conversations, not just press
quotes.

Epstein doesn't look up.

EPSTEIN

You have invariably shown finer
judgement than most, Maureen. John
recognises that.

MAUREEN

It's not just John. I want to do
all four of the boys –
individually. Where they live. Who
they are when the fans aren't
watching.

He finally meets her gaze.

EPSTEIN

And what are you hoping to find?

MAUREEN

(with increasing firmness)
Who they're becoming. Not the
legend – just the men. It's clear
the roles are evolving. Paul's the
diplomat. George is searching.
Ringo's observing everything. And
John... well, he's in flux.

EPSTEIN

(quietly amused)
Flux is one word for it.

MAUREEN

The Evening Standard wants this series. So do I. But more than that – I think the public's ready to know them as individuals. Not just mop-tops in suits.

Epstein rises and moves toward the window. Thoughtful. He lights a cigarette.

EPSTEIN

You realize what you're asking, Maureen. Privacy is sacred. Especially to John. And George's home is practically a temple now.

MAUREEN

No photographers. Just me, a recorder, and a notebook. No entourage. No gotcha questions. They know that's not my style.

Epstein pauses, staring through her, calculating.

EPSTEIN

We should consider the terms of engagement. No entourage is acceptable. We'll retain copy approval for factual accuracy, naturally. But the substance – the tone – I don't need surprises right now.

MAUREEN

You'll have copy approval for factual accuracy. But the substance – their words, their tone, the framing – that stays mine.

Epstein takes a long drag on his cigarette. Considering. Cautiously.

EPSTEIN

You'll begin with John?

MAUREEN
If he's willing.

EPSTEIN
He will be. He's been restless.
Daring someone to ask real
questions. Just...

(again, calculating)
We must be careful. His honesty can
be utterly forthright when his mind
is engaged.

MAUREEN
I'd expect nothing less.

Epstein returns to his desk and opens a small leather-bound
address book.

EPSTEIN
I'll schedule it for next week.
Kenwood. Weybridge. My office will
coordinate with you.

MAUREEN
Thank you, Brian.

She stands to leave. A soft BUZZ from the intercom. Epstein
presses a button, lighting a second cigarette from the
first.

EPSTEIN
(into intercom)
Yes, Wendy?

WENDY (V.O.)
Mr. Epstein, the American tour
promoters are here for the two
o'clock.

EPSTEIN (CONT'D)
(glancing at his watch.)
Thanks, Wendy. Give me two minutes.

He releases the button and turns fully back to Maureen. The
outside chaos held at bay.

EPSTEIN

This isn't about headlines. It's
about their respectability.
Remember that when he starts
talking... consider where those
words might travel.

MAUREEN

I will.

We don't see Epstein's relief.

We remain on his hand as it reaches for the intercom button.

Control reasserted through routine.

As Maureen exits quietly, Brian sighs and watches the door
close behind her.

EPSTEIN

(under his breath)

Let's hope the world's ready to
hear what he has to say.

He sighs deeply again and leans back, gazing at the London
skyline.

Alone now, the control slips. He pulls a bottle of unlabeled
pills from a desk drawer, casually tosses a handful in his
mouth, closes his eyes and swallows.

INT.. JOHN'S WEYBRIDGE HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY (MARCH 4,
1966)

The same room seen earlier. Books everywhere. On the
cluttered coffee table: notebooks, tea cups, a dog-eared
paperback – ALDOUS HUXLEY, "THE DOORS OF PERCEPTION," and
eight small green boxes with winking red lights. JOHN
LENNON, 25, pokes one whose light has just died.

JOHN

(to himself)

Another one gone...

He settles back into his armchair, a cup of tea balanced
precariously. Casual sweater and jeans. Hair longer now,
falling across his forehead. Relaxed. At ease.

MAUREEN CLEAVE, 32, sits opposite him. Notebook open. Tape recorder on the table between them. Her eyes move along the shelves: poetry, paperbacks, philosophy. COLIN WILSON. "THE OUTSIDER."

The atmosphere is intimate and conversational – two intelligent people thinking aloud.

MAUREEN

I have to say, John, this isn't what most people would expect from a pop star's living room.

JOHN

(smiling slightly)
What would they expect? Gold records on the walls and a jukebox?

MAUREEN

Something like that. Instead, I see...

She picks up a book.

MAUREEN (CONT'D)

Hugh Schonfield. THE PASSOVER PLOT. Not exactly typical reading for someone who sings "She Loves You."

John leans forward with excitement.

JOHN

(animated)
That's exactly the point, isn't it? Everyone thinks because we sing pop songs, we must be empty-headed. But why can't you make music and think at the same time?

John reaches for another book, sets it down without ceremony: BERTRAND RUSSELL. "WHY I AM NOT A CHRISTIAN."

JOHN (CONT'D)

I read everything I can get my hands on. Philosophy, religion, poetry. The more famous we get, the more I realize how little I actually know about... well,

everything.

MAUREEN

(scribbling with a practiced ease)

And what are you discovering in all this reading?

JOHN

(thoughtful)

That most of what we're taught to believe is just... stories. Useful stories, maybe, but stories nonetheless.

He picks up a slim volume. D.T. SUZUKI. "ZEN BUDDHISM."

JOHN (CONT'D)

Take Christianity. I was brought up Church of England, like most people. But then you read about other religions, other ways of thinking, and you realize... it's all just different attempts to explain the same mysteries.

MAUREEN

That's quite a shift from your Liverpool upbringing.

JOHN

(laughing)

My Aunt Mimi would have a fit if she heard me now. But that's what happens when you start thinking for yourself instead of just accepting what you're told.

Maureen studies her notes, then looks up.

MAUREEN

You mentioned Christianity specifically. How do you see its role in modern Britain?

JOHN

(settling back)

Honestly? I think it's dying. Not

the ideas – some of the ideas are brilliant. Love your neighbor, help the poor, all that. But the institution, the organized bit...

He shakes his head.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Look around. How many young people do you know who actually go to church? Who really believe in all the ritual and ceremony?

MAUREEN

And you think that's significant?

JOHN

(warming to the subject.)

I think it's inevitable. Christianity will go. It will vanish and shrink. I needn't argue about that; I'm right and I will be proved right.

He pauses, takes a sip of tea. Then, still casually–

JOHN (CONT'D)

We're more popular than Jesus now. I don't know which will go first, rock 'n' roll or Christianity. Jesus was all right, but his disciples were thick and ordinary. It's them twisting it that ruins it for me.

The words hang briefly. No drama. No emphasis. Maureen writes it down like any other observation.

John is still talking, but we don't hear what John says next.

We stay with Maureen's pen as it records the words.

Only later will we understand this moment as evidence.

MAUREEN

(thoughtful)

That's quite a statement.

JOHN

(shrugging)

Is it? Look at the evidence. We fill stadiums with kids who know every word to our songs. When's the last time you saw that kind of passion in a church?

He leans forward, earnest.

JOHN (CONT'D)

I'm not saying it's good or bad. I'm just observing what's happening. The world's changing. Young people are looking for meaning in different places.

MAUREEN

And you think pop music is providing that meaning?

JOHN

(considering)

Some of it, maybe. When we sing about love, or confusion, or growing up... maybe that speaks more directly than ancient parables.

He picks up RUBBER SOUL.

JOHN (CONT'D)

We're trying to say something real here. About memory. Change. Searching for something deeper than entertainment.

MAUREEN

So you see The Beatles as having a kind of... spiritual influence?

JOHN

(uncomfortable)

God, no. Don't make us sound like prophets. We're just four lads from Liverpool who got lucky.

He trails, then looks at her.

JOHN (CONT'D)
But if our music helps people
think, or feel less alone, or
question things they've taken for
granted... maybe that's useful.

EXT.. JOHN'S WEYBRIDGE HOME - CONTINUOUS

An MI5 surveillance van parked down the street. NIGEL FINCH
peers through binoculars. CLIVE BARROW scribbles furiously.

CLIVE
(whispering)
Twenty-three minutes straight! This
is clearly a propaganda session!

Nigel lowers the binoculars, sighs, and looks back at Clive.

NIGEL
It's called an interview, Clive.

CLIVE
The gestures! The leaning forward!
Classic ideological indoctrination!

NIGEL
(deadpan)
Or he's talking.

INT.. JOHN'S WEYBRIDGE HOME - CONTINUOUS

John indicates an open book nearby. JOSEPH CAMPBELL. "THE
HERO WITH A THOUSAND FACES." Marginal notes in pencil.

JOHN
All religions start the same. Love.
Compassion. Then come the rules.
The hierarchies.

Dismissive wave.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Politics. Power instead of truth.

MAUREEN
And young people are rejecting

that?

JOHN

Anything that feels imposed. They want authenticity.

He sits, thoughtful.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Maybe that's why the music connects. We're not pretending to have answers. We're figuring it out in public.

MAUREEN

How has fame changed your sense of responsibility?

JOHN

(rueful)

It makes it urgent. When millions are listening, you can't waste it.

A rare vulnerability.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Not to preach. Just to be honest.

MAUREEN

And that's what this reading is about?

JOHN

Maybe. Or maybe I'm just trying to understand where the world's going.

He looks out the window.

JOHN (CONT'D)

The old certainties don't work anymore.

MAUREEN

And sometimes people look to you.

JOHN

(smiling)

Scary thought.

They laugh. The recorder clicks off.

EXT.. JOHN'S WEYBRIDGE HOME - CONTINUOUS

Maureen walks to her car. The surveillance van idles.

CLIVE

Interview concluded. Recommend
debrief.

NIGEL

(takes the radio.)
Disregard. Standard interview.

He starts the van.

NIGEL

Sometimes, Clive, a conversation is
just a conversation.

The van pulls away. The house remains. Quiet. Ordinary.

Through the front window, the living room sits exactly as
before. Sunlight falls across a low bookshelf.

Tucked between dense paperbacks: a battered copy of "ALICE'S
ADVENTURES IN WONDERLAND". Spine cracked. Well-loved.